

A SEASONAL KITCHEN SPELLBOOK

THE MAGIC IS IN THE MAKING

FOR MAKING THE EVERYDAY FEEL
A LITTLE MORE MAGICAL

AUTUMN • SOUPS • POTIONS • FAMILIARS

FROM OUR KITCHEN

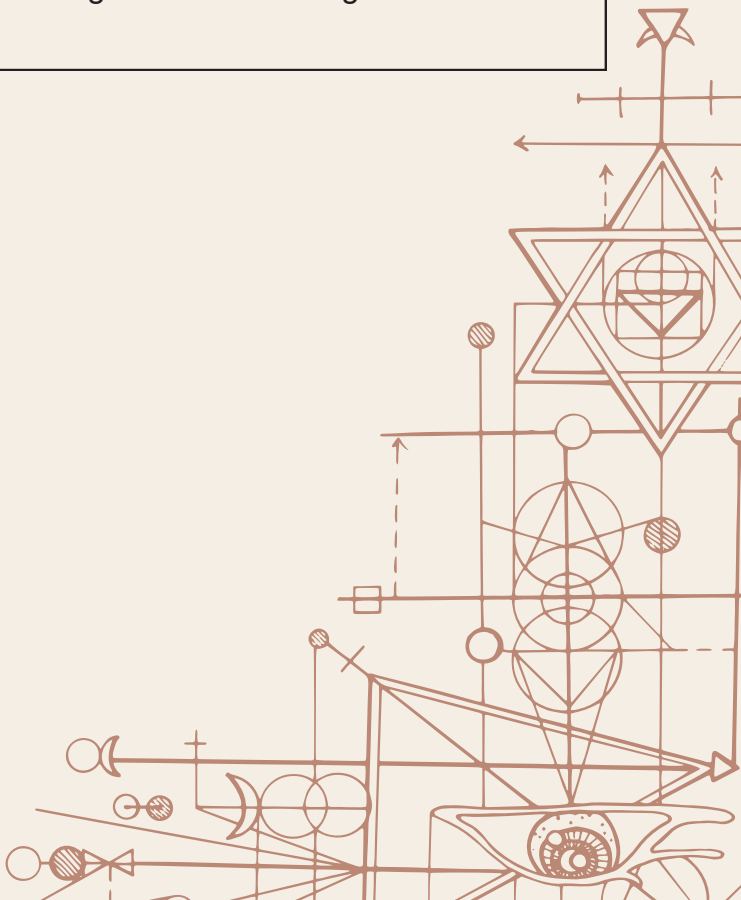
The magic is in how we live it.

Our kitchen is seasonal, messy, and a little bit magical.

In my family, we save our vegetable scraps and every Friday take them to a nearby farm to feed the goats. We take Tylenol when we have headaches, and we also keep ginger, turmeric and elderberry on hand. We try to eat organic, but we don't hesitate to buy non-organic when the budget calls for it. We love our local farmers market and try to grow our own, though most of what we eat still comes from the Texas' beloved H-E-B grocer and trusty Costco. We buy the prepared meals when our weeks call for it. We will also light candles and play region-appropriate music for a whipped meal on a random Tuesday.

THE MAGIC IS IN THE MAKING

We cook together, make messes together and clean up together.
This isn't about doing food—or family—perfectly.
It's about noticing that ordinary tasks can become rituals when we give them our attention.
The magic isn't something we add to the making. The magic is in the making.



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THE CAULDRON

HARVEST MOON

Butternut Squash & Sweet Potato Soup

COLLECT

Butternut squash • Sweet potato • Yellow onion • Garlic • Chicken stock • Coconut milk • Honey • Smoked paprika • Nutmeg • Salt • Black pepper • Lemon • Butter or olive oil

MEASURE
1 whole butternut squash, peeled & cubed
1 medium sweet potato
1 yellow onion, diced
3 cloves garlic, chopped
3–4 cups chicken stock
½ can full-fat coconut milk
½ tsp honey
⅛ tsp smoked paprika
Smallest pinch nutmeg
Salt + black pepper
Small squeeze lemon

THE MAKING

1. Set your cauldron over low heat. Butter or oil first. Send in the onion with a couple pinches of salt and pepper and let her soften.
2. Then the garlic. Keep your fire low. We want her soft and fragrant, never bitter.
3. Bring in the squash and enough stock to nearly cover her. Cover and let the cauldron quietly bubble until the squash yields to your fork. The squash does not own a clock.
4. Honey to soften the edges. Smoked paprika for warmth. Nutmeg—careful. She has never understood moderation.
5. Blend. If your spoon can stand at attention, give her more stock. You want velvet.
6. Now the sweet potato, cut small. Simmer until so tender it nearly becomes part of the spell—but not quite. The pleasure is forgetting it is there until your spoon finds one
7. Turn the fire down. Stir in half the coconut milk. A tiny squeeze of lemon wakes the whole cauldron
8. Taste. Listen. The recipe has stopped being in charge now. You're the witch.

WASTE NOTHING — FOR TOMORROW MORNING

The other half of the coconut milk already has plans. With a1:1 ratio, loosen the coconut milk with water, add chia seeds, honey and the smallest pinch of salt. Shake it all together in your air-tight container, then leave it in the cold overnight. By morning it has transformed to delicious chia pudding. Add Berries, Granola and more honey drizzle in your fanciest glass for a beautiful fruit parfait.

THE CAULDRON

DEAD MAN'S CAULDRON

Beef, Fingerling Potato & Vegetable Stew

COLLECT
Coconut oil • Yellow onion • Salt + pepper • Celery • Garlic • Red + green pepper • Beef stock • Fingerling or golden potatoes • Skirt steak • Sweet potato • Cauliflower • Bay leaves • Thyme • Basil • Oregano

MEASURE
2 tbl coconut oil
1 yellow onion
A couple pinches salt + pepper
2 celery stalks
1 tbl chopped garlic
½ red pepper + ½ green pepper
2 boxes beef stock
10–20 fingerlings or 5 golden potatoes
Skirt steak
1 small sweet potato
1 cup small cauliflower
2 bay leaves • 1 sprig thyme • basil • oregano

THE MAKING

Low boil 10 min.

Now: salt and pepper the skirt steak and cut into spoon-fed pieces; sear on med-high heat to med-rare — set aside the way he did the chores you gave him.

And for all your sweetness, add 1 small sweet potato chopped smaller than pinky-nails.

1 cup of small cauliflower (bits of his brain where it belongs)
2 bay leaves for empty whispers
Reclaim your thyme (1 sprig)
A sprinkle of basil for your next romance
Brush it off with a shake of oregano

Serve in deep bowls with the pieces of his last steak on top.

MAKE IT MAGICAL

Since I was a kid, my mom spiced up soup night by serving her mixture in a mug.
When you find ways to break out of routine, even in the smallest of ways such as exchanging your bowl for a coffee mug, you make life a little more magical.

THE CAULDRON

WHITE WITCH

Roasted Garlic & White Bean Soup

COLLECT
Cannellini beans • Whole garlic • Leek • Parsnip • Stock • Olive oil • Lemon • Salt • Pepper • Fresh sage

MEASURE
2 cans cannellini beans • 1 whole head garlic • 1 large leek • 1 medium parsnip • About 4 cups stock • 2 tbl olive oil • ½ lemon • Salt + pepper • A few sage leaves

THE MAKING
Roast the garlic until every clove slips from its skin without a fight.

Leeks trap dirt between their layers, so prep matters as much as cooking. Cut off the dark green tops and the root end, slice the white and pale green part lengthwise, then rinse really well between the layers. After that, slice it into thin half-moons. Let the leek soften slowly in olive oil and salt until she loses her edges and turns silky. Around 6-8 minutes on medium-low heat. No browning.
We are casting a spell to end the burning of all White Witches. *White refers to “good,” not to be confused with the shade of anyone’s appearance, but a reflection of the light that lives within her.

Add sliced parsnip, beans, roasted garlic and stock.

Let them simmer until everything has forgotten it was separate.

Blend only half the pot. A White Witch still has secrets.

Return it to the fire. Lemon. Pepper. Taste before you salt again. Crisp the sage for the top if the evening calls for ceremony or add those crispy little onions we put on top of green bean casserole.

MAKE IT MAGIC
Find a witch hat to wear and play your favorite song when you were 12 years old. There’s nothing more magical to inspire your manifestations than tapping into your inner child.

POTIONS & BREWS

LOVE POTION

Dark Cherry & Blueberry Smoothie

COLLECT
Raw almonds • Frozen dark cherries • Frozen blueberries • Kale • Coconut oil • Lemon

MEASURE
¼ cup raw almonds • 1 cup cold water • 1 cup dark cherries • ½ cup blueberries • 1 small handful kale • 1 tsp coconut oil • Juice of ½ lemon

THE MAKING
Almonds and cold water first. Blend until nearly milk, but leave a little texture. Love should have a little mystery.

Add the cherries, blueberries, kale and coconut oil. Yes, kale. It keeps the love healthy.

Squeeze in the lemon. Don’t skip the acid. The best love has boundaries.

Blend until dark enough to look suspicious.

If she needs loosening, add liquid sparingly.

MAKE IT MAGIC
Serve fresh and cold in the prettiest glass you have or a frozen beer mug!
Find twirly straws or straws with spoons on the end to make your babies’ day.

POTIONS & BREWS

DEATH'S KISS

Golden Coconut Chai



COLLECT
Golden Masala Chai • Full-fat coconut milk • Honey
Optional: fresh ginger • fresh turmeric

MEASURE
1 serving Golden Masala Chai • ¼–½ cup coconut milk • Honey to taste

THE MAKING
Brew the chai. Pour it into your favorite heavy mug. Coconut milk. Honey. Stir.

That is enough. Death's Kiss does not need to be complicated.

If the night calls for more, grate in fresh ginger or turmeric while she steeps, then strain.

MAKE IT MAGIC
Turn off the overhead lights. Light a candle. Sit down while you drink it. Five minutes sipping and watching the flame is a meditation and counts for your mental health..

POTIONS & BREWS

BELCHING HONEY

Fermented Garlic & Raw Honey

COLLECT
Fresh garlic • Raw honey • A clean glass jar

MEASURE
Enough peeled garlic to loosely fill ⅓–½ of the jar • Enough raw honey to coat and cover it • Generous headspace

THE MAKING
Peel the garlic and put it into a clean, dry jar. Cover with raw honey. Leave room above it—the honey has earned its name.
As the garlic releases itself into the honey, the mixture loosens and will begin to bubble.
Do not fear the bubbles. Respect the bubbles.

After its first few days of sitting in your cool, dark pantry, you will “belch” the honey.
Twist the lid off enough for the gases to escape. Tighten the lid back, then give it a little twist upside down. The wrist twist keeps everything fermenting equally.

You will belch the honey every day or two from her forward for a couple of weeks. Once the honey turns into a liquid, it’s ready to serve on a spoon.

MAKE IT MAGIC - THE WRIST TWIST

Do a little curtsy with the writst twist. It feels silly and that’s the point.
Habit stack ways to laugh at yourself every day.
On the days you belch the honey, remember that you are a woman who sees ahead (to cold season and beyond). See yourself standing there as the woman who cares for her family with nature as her partner. You are loving yourself as much as you love your kids.

POTIONS & BREWS

DRAGON'S BREATH

Spiced Apple Cider Vinegar Tonic

COLLECT

Apple cider vinegar • Orange • Lemon • Fresh ginger • Garlic • Cinnamon sticks • Star anise • Cayenne • Honey

MEASURE

About 4 cups pasteurized apple cider vinegar, 5% acidity • 1 orange • 1 lemon • 2–3 inches fresh ginger • 4–6 garlic cloves • 1 cinnamon stick • 2–3 star anise • Cayenne to taste • Honey to taste

THE MAKING

Wash the citrus, ginger and garlic well. Thinly slice the citrus and ginger and lightly crush the garlic. Into a clean jar they go with cinnamon and star anise. Add enough cayenne to give the dragon teeth.

Heat the apple cider vinegar to 190–195°F — steaming and just shy of a boil. Pour it over the ingredients, making sure everything is thoroughly heated and covered.

Seal the jar and let time do what fire cannot: 10–30 days in a cool, dark place, depending on how fierce you want your dragon.

Strain very well.

Then sweeten the strained vinegar with honey to taste.

A witch can also skip the honey altogether. Honey is there for flavor balance, not because the recipe requires it to function.

Refrigerate after opening.

MIND THE CAULDRON

Keep the solids covered while they infuse, strain well, and refrigerate after opening.
If you see mold, unexpected bubbling, or anything that smells truly wrong, the spell is over. Discard it.

LITTLE WITCHES & FAMILIARS

MONSTER MASH

COLLECT
Pumpkin purée • Oats • Nut butter • Chia • Honey • Cinnamon • Vanilla • Salt

MEASURE
½ cup pumpkin • 1½ cups oats • ½ cup nut butter • 2 tbl chia • 2–3 tbl honey • 1 tsp cinnamon • 1 tsp vanilla • Tiny pinch salt

THE MAKING
Put everything in a bowl and hand your little witches and warlocks the spoon.

This is where you stop caring what the kitchen looks like.

Let them mix. Let it rest for a few minutes. Then roll.

Some become balls. Some become blobs. One will inexplicably become a snake. They're all monsters. It counts.

MAKE IT MAGIC - CLEANUP

Have a wet rag on hand for each kid, but let go of the need to clean as you go.
Focus on the feeling of your breath as you watch them play.
Remind yourself that you have a broom, a mop, and a bathtub.
When you clean up later, pop in those earbuds and play your favorite song. You did great today, mom. Enjoy yourself while you clean.

HELLHOUND TREATS

COLLECT
Pumpkin purée • Oats • Eggs • Peanut butter

MEASURE
1 cup pumpkin • 2½ cups oats • 2 eggs • ½ cup peanut butter

THE MAKING
Heat the oven to 350°F.

Turn the oats into rough flour with your blender or food processor or do it by hand with a mortar and pestle.

Mix with pumpkin, eggs and peanut butter until you have a workable dough.

Cut bones or pumpkins if it pleases you; your hellhound does not care. Bake until firm and dry.

Cool completely before summoning the beast.

MIND THE CAULDRON - KEEP YOUR PUP SAFE

Peanut butter must contain NO xylitol/birch sugar. It's not good for our furry friends. Please check labels and stay mindful.

FAMILIAR'S GARDEN

COLLECT
Catnip seeds • Potting soil • A small pot with drainage • Water

MEASURE
A small pinch of seeds • Enough soil to fill the vessel

THE MAKING
Fill the vessel. Scatter the seeds and cover them only lightly. Water gently and put the garden somewhere bright.

Keep the soil lightly moist while the seeds wake.

Then give them light, water and time.

Your familiar will handle the rest. And probably knock the pot off the windowsill so best to put it on your patio or outdoors should weather allow.

WASTE NOTHING

Use an old mug, chipped bowl or food container if you can give it proper drainage. The garden does not need to be pretty to grow something. You could also place it on a cookie sheet instead of outside.

A LETTER FROM MAMA MANDI

be the magic you wish to see

We don't say grace before we eat, but (most nights) we thank the farmers, the truck drivers, the grocers, the animals, and the vegetables for their service.

Then we rub our hands together until they're warm and on the count of three we show our palms to our food and say,
"YUMMMMMMM."
To share our good energy with the food. Is that science? Maybe.
Is it magic? Feels like it. But mostly, it's four little kids stopping for three seconds to think about the food in front of them and the people sitting beside them?
And that is the point. To just take an extra minute to notice.
That is really what I mean when I talk about magic

I think that matters because so much of motherhood, and adulthood, can start feeling like maintenance. On some days, survival.

Feed them. Clean it. Fold it. Buy it. Make it. Do it again tomorrow.

But the exact same dinner can feel completely different when you put on music, use the pretty glass, let the kids make a mess, or decide that tonight the nuggets get served in paper boats instead of on plates.

Nothing monumental changed, except the way you were paying attention.
.
Take what you like from these pages and keep doing it long after October is over.
The ritual does not have to be impressive to matter.
It only matters that you notice yourself living.

The magic isn't something we add to the making.
The magic is in the making.

Thank you for sharing your kitchen with us.

Visit us at BeThereForHer.com and AIWorksForHer.com
Follow Mandi on the socials @MandiJoyBeck and tune into AI Mom Podcast!
I'd love to see what you make, what you change, what your kids ruin, what becomes tradition, and the little bits of magic weaving their way into your kitchen.